Journal of Psychological Inquiry
2023, Vol. 27, No. 2, pp. 39-48
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BLAME AND PUNISHMENT: ROLE OF VARIOUS FAULT ATTRIBUTIONS AND OTHER FACTORS IN PREDICTING PEOPLE'S ORIENTATION TOWARD PUNISHING JUVENILE OFFENDERS

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Abstract – We asked a convenient sample of 155 adults to read two crime reports, presented in a random order, describing the adjudication of one juvenile male charged with assault and one charged with possession of an illicit drug. As a between-subjects factor, participants were randomly assigned to imagine that the juveniles in both crime reports were either a 14-year-old or a 17-year-old. After reading the crime reports, participants were asked to respond to a series of questions assessing their beliefs concerning (a) the extent to which the juvenile, his parents, and society are ultimately responsible for the juvenile being caught up in the juvenile justice system, (b) the likelihood the juvenile would continue to commit crimes again in the future, and (c) the appropriateness of the judge's sentencing decision. Results revealed that while participants attributed the most blame to the juvenile, himself, the extent to which participants attributed blame to other external sources (e.g., his parents or society, generally) depended on the crime. Participants blamed the juvenile, himself, less, and blamed society (and to a lesser degree, the juvenile's parents) more, when evaluating a juvenile convicted of possession of illicit drugs than when evaluating a juvenile who was convicted of assault. Interestingly, each type of fault attribution significantly predicted participants' beliefs concerning the appropriateness of the punishment each juvenile received. Implications and future directions are discussed.

The American public has long held conflicting attitudes on how to handle individuals who break the law, particularly if the individual is under the age of 18. Since its creation over a century ago, the juvenile justice system has consistently wavered between "get tough" policies that are focused on punishment and other, more compassionate, policies focused on rehabilitation (Feld, 2017). Currently, the American public tends to simultaneously believe that while juveniles who break the law should be punished – and, in some cases, quite severely – there should also be a compassionate understanding of juvenile development within the system so that juveniles are not forever harmed by their adolescent indiscretions (Roberts, 2004).

A recent study by Bolin et al. (2021) clearly illustrates the extent to which the American public hold such conflictual cognitions. In their study, Bolin et al. (2021) asked a nationally representative sample of 1,494 U.S. adults to complete a wide range of items assessing, among other things, their views concerning the goals of juvenile justice and their opinions concerning certain sentencing decisions (e.g., blended sentencing). Results revealed that while most of those sampled believed that rehabilitation and child welfare (i.e., looking out for the best interests of the juvenile) should be important goals within the juvenile justice system, a majority (around 60%) *also* believed that deterrence (i.e., punishment as a way to deter crime), retribution (i.e., making sure juveniles get the punishment they deserve), and incapacitation (i.e., locking juveniles up) should also be important goals for the juvenile justice system. Further, a majority of those sampled believed that severe sentences in which juvenile offenders spend at least some of their time in the adult criminal justice system would be much more likely to produce negative consequences for the juvenile (e.g., being beaten or raped by adult criminals). However, depending on the circumstance (e.g., for juveniles convicted of murder), up to 80% of people reported that they favored or strongly favored juveniles serving some of their sentence in the adult criminal justice system.

Despite the general public's conflicting attitudes concerning the goals and appropriate sentencing of juvenile offenders within the juvenile justice system,

people tend to be united in the belief that the age of the offender should be considered in sentencing decisions. For instance, using mixed-methods design, Bradley et al. (2012) found that people tend to understand that younger adolescents may have poor impulse control and, due to ongoing changes in the brain during adolescence, may not fully understand the long-term consequences of their actions. As such, participants who were asked to make judgments concerning the culpability and punishment of a 11-, 14- or 17-year-old male juvenile offender convicted of murder indicated that, all else being equal, they believe that the younger juveniles were less culpable and deserving of punishment than the older juveniles. More specifically, across participants' judgments concerning the culpability of the juvenile and deservingness of punishment, participants indicated that the 11-year-old was less culpable and deserving of punishment than the 14- year-old and, similarly, the 14-year-old was less culpable and deserving of punishment than the 17-year-old. Further, and perhaps most importantly, there was a linear relationship between the age of juvenile offender and participants' beliefs that age should be considered in sentencing such that the older the juvenile offender, the more participants agreed a judge should consider age at sentencing.

The findings from Bradley et al. (2012) demonstrating the importance of the age of a juvenile offender in the general public's orientation toward punishment were not surprising. An impressive volume of research consistently finds that the public is generally less punitive toward younger than older juvenile offenders. For instance, Scott et al. (2006) conducted a series of studies to evaluate the extent to which the general public's perceptions and attitudes about the culpability and appropriate punishment for juvenile offenders are affected by the offender's age, race, and physical appearance. Consistent with results reported by Bradley et al. (2012), Scott et al. (2006) found that the age of a juvenile offender was an important mitigative factor when it comes to people's perceptions of the juvenile offender and recommendations for sentencing. For instance, as compared to those who were told the offender was 15 or 20 years old, participants who were told that the offender was 12 years old believed that the offender was less able to appreciate the consequences of his actions and the impact of his crime on others, and overall believed that he was less responsible for his actions. Further, additional analyses revealed there were stark differences in participants' beliefs concerning the extent to which the juvenile could be rehabilitated and whether he should be tried as an adult. Participants believed the 12-year-old had a better chance of being rehabilitated than either the 15- or 20-year-olds presented, and more strongly disagreed that the 12-year-old should be tried as an adult. Interestingly, and contrary to the authors' expectations, other characteristics of the offender (e.g., race and physical demeanor) failed to produce consistent effects on participants' attitudes or beliefs.

Although prior research has established that the general public tends to believe that the age of the juvenile offender should be considered as an important factor in sentencing decisions, it is important to note that people believe sentencing decisions within the juvenile justice system should also be impacted by a myriad of other factors, such as the type and severity of the crime. For instance, in a seminal study on the topic, Ghetti and Redlich (2001) asked a sample of college students within the U.S. to make a sentencing recommendation for an 11-, 14-, or 17-year-old male who committed a felony crime against a person (firing a gun) or property (arson) that ultimately resulted in personal injury to a victim or death. The researchers found that, regardless of the age of the juvenile, participants prescribed harsher sentences and more punitive views towards a juvenile whose criminal actions killed rather than injured a person, and especially when the crime involved a violent offense (i.e., firing a gun).

Interestingly, while sentencing recommendations in Ghetti and Redlich (2001) appeared to be completely unaffected by the age of the juvenile offender, it is important to note that age of the juvenile offender was still a significant factor impacting participants' judgments concerning the culpability of the juvenile as well as their perceptions concerning the juvenile's competency to stand trial. More specifically, Ghetti and Redlich (2001) found that the older the juvenile, the more participants believed that the juvenile was responsible for his actions, competent to stand trial, and able to understand the legal consequences of his actions. However, it is important to note that the effects of age of juvenile on many of these beliefs were moderated by other crime-related factors such as the type and outcome of the crime. For instance, an 11-year-old who shot and killed the victim was seen as being just as competent to stand trial as an older, 17-year-old who shot but only injured the victim.

Taken together, the results of studies like Ghetti and Redlich (2001) suggest there is a need to have a more nuanced view when it comes to understanding the general public's attitudes and opinions concerning juvenile justice. Clearly, the American public believes that sentencing decisions – and perceptions of individual responsibility – depend on a wide-range of circumstances. Although age of the offender and type or

severity of crime are some well-established factors (Walker & Wooder, 2011), there are potentially a myriad of others that may impact people's opinions concerning juvenile justice.

Current Study

A great deal of attention in the literature has been dedicated to understanding (a) how various characteristics of the offender (e.g., age of the juvenile) and circumstances related to the criminal offence (e.g., type or severity of crime) may impact the general public's perceptions of a juvenile offender (e.g., perceptions of culpability) and (b) how all these factors may relate to or otherwise impact the general public's beliefs concerning the appropriate punishment for juvenile crime. Interestingly, much of this research has only examined the extent to which people believe that juvenile offenders, themselves, are personally responsible or "culpable" for their behavior or fate. Although attributions of personal responsibility are certainly important, there is evidence to believe that people tend to attribute blame to other sources, beyond the juvenile offenders, themselves. For instance, Brank and Weisz (2004) found that the general public believes that various external factors, beyond the juveniles, themselves, contribute to juvenile delinquency. Beyond blaming the juvenile, a majority of the respondents (i.e., nearly 70%) also attributed blame to the juvenile's parents.

A rich and extensive supportive literature within social psychology (see Kelly & Michela, 1980, and Wiener, 1986 for reviews) demonstrates that people can make internal attributions in which they blame individuals, themselves, for an unfortunate circumstance (e.g., blaming the juveniles, themselves, for ending up in the juvenile justice system) *and* external attributions in which they attribute at least some responsibility for an unfortunate circumstance to outside factors (e.g., blaming juveniles' parents for the juveniles ending up in the juvenile justice system). Unfortunately, there exists a paucity of research examining the relative degree to which people attribute responsibility to outside factors (e.g., the juvenile's parents or society, generally) for a juvenile's criminal behavior, and whether these external attributions of responsibility may uniquely predict people's endorsement of relatively harsh sentencing decisions for younger vs. older juvenile offenders. A systematic review of the literature yielded only a handful of studies that have attempted to examine people's endorsement of internal *and* external attributions of fault for juvenile offenders' criminal actions. Although research suggests that people may attribute more responsibility to external forces (e.g., parents and society) for certain crimes (Aizpurua et al., 2020), and perhaps especially for younger rather than older juvenile offenders (Brank et al., 2011), research has yet to systematically examine the extent to which these attributions may uniquely predict people's opinions concerning the sentencing of juvenile offenders. The present study was created to address this gap in the literature.

As an extension of prior work examining the general public's beliefs and opinions concerning the culpability and punishment of juvenile offenders convicted of a crime, the current study was designed with two major goals in mind. First, the current study was designed to examine the extent to which people blame juveniles, their parents, and society, generally for the juvenile ultimately ending up in the juvenile justice system. Second, and perhaps most importantly, the current study was designed to examine the extent to which internal and external attributions of blame uniquely predict people's orientation toward punishing a juvenile offender. In general, we predicted that attributions of responsibility would uniquely predict participants' orientation towards severely punishing the juvenile. More specifically, and consistent with attribution theory (Weiner, 1986), the more participants blame the juvenile, himself, for ultimately ending up in the juvenile justice system, the more they would endorse a harsh sentencing decision. In contrast, the more participants attribute responsibility to outside forces (e.g., the juvenile's parents or society, generally), the less they would endorse harsh sentencing decisions.

Method

Participants

A total of 155 adults[1] (56% female; 44% males), who ranged in age from 18 to 66 years (M_{age} = 30.05, *SD* = 12.76), were recruited to participate in the current study via snowball sampling through advertisements posted on Facebook, LinkedIn, and Instagram. A majority of the sample (i.e., 71%) self-identified as White/European American, with only a small percentage self-identifying as Black/African American (12%), Asian/Pacific Islander (7%), or Hispanic American or LatinX (3%). Approximately 4% identified as belonging

[1]A total of 176 individuals opened the survey link. However, initial screening revealed that 21 of these individuals opened but did not complete even a small portion of the study. Because these individuals did not provide useable data, they were excluded from all analyses.

to more than one racial group, and 3% stated that they preferred not to respond. Approximately 41% of respondents self-identified as moderately to strongly conservative, 18% self-identified as politically moderate, and 25% self-identified as moderately to strongly liberal. Approximately 16% indicated that they would prefer not to state their political orientation.

Materials and Procedure

After providing their consent to participate in the study, and completing a short demographics questionnaire, participants were asked to read two crime reports, presented in a random order, describing the adjudication of a juvenile male[2] charged with assault (i.e., for stabbing a man) and one charged with possession of an illicit drug (i.e., crystal methamphetamine). As a between-subjects factor, participants were randomly assigned to imagine that the juveniles in both crime reports were either a 14-year-old or a 17-year-old. Across both crime reports, participants were told that the judge presiding over the case sentenced the juvenile to 12 months in a juvenile detention center (see Appendix).

Immediately after reading each crime report, participants were asked to respond to seven items that were created to assess their beliefs concerning (a) who (i.e., the juvenile and his parents) or what (i.e., society) were to blame for the juvenile's fate, (b) the likelihood the juvenile would end up back in jail again in the future (i.e., perceptions of recidivism), and (c) the appropriateness of punishment. More specifically, the first three items asked participants to indicate how much they disagreed or agreed that it was (1) the juvenile's fault (2) the juvenile's parents' fault, and (3) society's fault that the juvenile ended up in the juvenile justice system (items were adapted from Wadian et al., 2018), using a 6-point Likert scale that ranged from 1 (*disagree a lot*) to 6 (*agree a lot*). Using the same 6-point scale, participants were asked to respond to another three items that were created to assess their beliefs the juvenile would commit crimes again in the future (e.g., "I believe this juvenile will continue to break the law when he gets older" and "I believe this juvenile will eventually end up in prison"). Participants' responses on these three items demonstrated an acceptable level of internal consistency ($\alpha = .70$). Consequently, participants' responses across the three items were averaged to create an overall likelihood of recidivism index, where higher scores reflected a stronger belief that the juvenile would likely continue to commit crimes in the future. The final item asked participants to evaluate the severity of the judge's sentencing decision using a 101-point sliding scale that ranged from -50 (*the sentence was far too lenient*) to 50 (*the sentence was far too strict*) with a midpoint of 0 (*the sentence was appropriate*).

Results

Attributions of Fault

A 2 (type of crime: assault vs possession) × 2 (age of juvenile: 14-year-old vs 17-year-old) × 3 (source of fault: juvenile vs. parent vs. society) mixed ANOVA was conducted on participants' fault ratings to examine the extent to which they blamed a juvenile, his parents, and society for the juvenile getting caught in the juvenile justice system. Results revealed that the main effect of source of fault was significant, $F(2, 286) = 64.33$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .31$. Post hoc analyses revealed that there was a clear hierarchy in who or what participants blamed for the juvenile ultimately ending up in the juvenile justice system. As seen in Table 1, the juvenile was perceived to be most culpable for his current circumstance, followed by his parents and then society, generally. However, this main effect of source of fault was qualified by a significant two-way interaction of type of crime × source of fault, $F(2, 286) = 9.47$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .06$.

Table 1
Means (and Standard Deviations) for the Main Effect of Source of Fault

	Juvenile	Parents	Society
Mean	4.81^c	3.76^b	3.13^a
(*SD*)	(1.17)	(1.30)	(1.39)

Note. Means with different superscripts differ at $p < .05$ as determined by post hoc analyses using Bonferroni adjustment for family-wise error.

As depicted in Table 2, simple effects tests probing this interaction revealed that participants blamed the juvenile, himself, more when evaluating a juvenile convicted of assault than when they evaluated a juvenile who was convicted of drug possession. In contrast, when evaluating the extent to which the juvenile's parents and society, generally, are at fault for the juvenile's behavior, participants blamed society, generally – and tended to blame the juvenile's parents –

[2] Considering that (a) a majority of juveniles within the juvenile justice system are males (Ehrmann et al., 2019), and (b) most published work on juvenile delinquency examines people's beliefs and attitudes toward male juvenile offenders, the present study solely focused on examining people's beliefs and attitudes toward male juvenile offenders.

more when evaluating a juvenile that was convicted of possession than one that was convicted of assault. Surprisingly, age of the juvenile offender failed to produce any effects on participants' fault ratings, all *p*s > .16.

Table 2
Results of Simple Effects Tests Probing the Two-Way Interaction of Type of Crime × Source of Fault

	Assault *M* (*SD*)	**Possession** *M* (*SD*)	*F*(1, 143)	η_p^2
Juvenile	4.95 (*1.30*)	4.62 (*1.38*)	10.08**	.07
Juvenile's Parents	3.71 (*1.45*)	3.87 (*1.37*)	2.78+	.02
Society	3.01 (*1.57*)	3.23 (*1.54*)	4.04*	.03

Note. +*p* < .10, **p* < .05, ***p* < .01

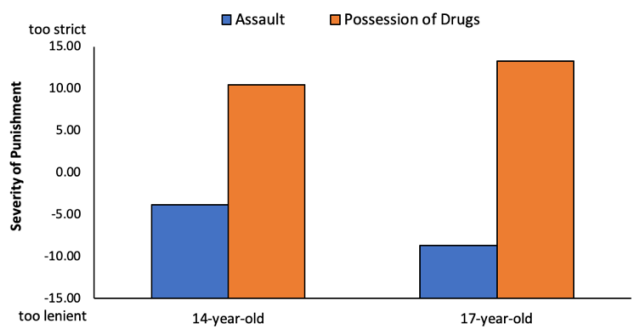

Figure 1
Bar Graph Depicting Participants' Perceptions Concerning the Appropriateness of the Punishment as a Function of Age of Juvenile Offender and Type of Crime.

Note. Higher scores on the perceptions of the punishment measure reflect the belief that a sentence of 12-months was too strict. Lower scores reflect the belief that the punishment was too lenient. A score of 0 reflects the belief that the sentence was appropriate.

Perceptions of the Punishment

Preliminary Analyses

Prior to examining the factors that may predict participants' perceptions concerning the appropriateness of the 12-month sentence the juveniles received, a preliminary 2 (type of crime: assault vs possession) × 2 (age of juvenile: 14-year-old vs 17-year-old) mixed ANOVA was conducted on participants' appropriateness of sentencing rating for both juveniles, depicted in Figure 1. Although there was no main effect of age of juvenile on participants' ratings, $F(1, 138) = .15$, $p = .70$, the main effect of type of crime was significant, $F(1, 138) = 96.18$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .41$. Participants believed that a sentence of 12 months was more strict when evaluating a case of possession ($M = 11.79$, $SD = 18.30$) than when evaluating a case of assault ($M = -6.16$, $SD = 19.96$)[3]. However, this significant main effect of type of crime was qualified by a significant interaction between type of crime and age of the juvenile offender, $F(1, 138) = 4.23$, $p = .042$, $\eta_p^2 = .03$. Simple effects tests probing the interaction of type of crime and age of juvenile offender revealed that participants believed that a sentence of 12 months was more strict for possession than assault, $F(1, 138) = 31.38$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .19$, particularly when the juvenile was described as being 17 years old, $F(1, 138) = 67.48$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .33$,

To more closely examine the interaction, we conducted an additional series of exploratory one-sample *t*-tests to examine whether participants' ratings in each condition significantly varied from 0. Considering that a rating of 0 on the 101-point scale would reflect the belief that the 12-month sentencing decision was appropriate, it stands to reason that a series of one-sample *t*-tests examining how much participants' ratings varied from 0 would yield valuable information about the degree to which participants believed the sentencing decision in each condition was appropriate. Further, by inspecting whether mean scores in each condition were positive or negative, we could more directly identify whether participants believed the sentencing decision was either too strict (indicated by positive values) or too lenient (indicated by negative values). As seen in Table 3, results of this series of exploratory analyses revealed that, regardless of the age of the juvenile, participants uniformly believed that a sentence of 12 months for possession of an illicit drug was too strict. However, when evaluating a case of assault, participants tended to believe that the older juvenile should have been sentenced more harshly for his violent offense than the younger juvenile. That is, while those who evaluated a case in which a 14-year-old was convicted of assault believed a 12-month sentence to a juvenile detention center was appropriate

[3] While positive values on this measure reflect the belief that the sentence was too strict, negative values reflect the belief that the sentence was too lenient.

Table 3
Results of the Series of One-Sample t-tests Examining Participants' Appropriateness of Punishment Ratings

		n	*M* (*SD*)	t	Cohen's *d*
14-year-old	Assault	75	-3.37 (*18.40*)	1.59	.18
	Drug Possession	77	11.29 (*17.81*)	5.56***	.63
17-year-old	Assault	70	-8.74 (*21.15*)	3.46***	.41
	Drug Possession	69	12.87 (*19.19*)	5.57***	.67

Note. ***$p < .001$

Table 4
Results of Regression Analyses Predicting Participants' Appropriateness of Punishment Ratings Toward a Juveniles Convicted of Assault and a Juvenile Convicted of Possession

	Assault			**Possession**		
	b (SE)	β	*t*	b (SE)	β	*t*
Juvenile	-4.71 (1.05)	-.31	4.49***	-2.96 (1.04)	-.22	2.84**
Juvenile's Parents	-2.44 (1.00)	-.18	2.44*	0.82 (1.08)	.06	0.76
Society	4.80 (.92)	.37	5.21***	2.13 (.97)	.17	2.20*
Recidivism	-4.68 (1.31)	-.25	3.57***	-5.69 (1.47)	-.30	3.89***

Note. *$p < .05$, **$p < .01$, ***$p < .001$

for the crime, those who were told the juvenile was 17 years old believed the sentence was too lenient.

Factors Predicting Participants' Perceptions Of The Punishment

Two linear regressions, one for each type of crime, were conducted to explore the relative extent to which the three fault attributions uniquely predict people's perceptions concerning the appropriateness of the judge's sentencing decision for each juvenile. In each of these regressions, participants' perceptions concerning the appropriateness of the juvenile's punishment ratings were regressed onto their various fault attributions and perceptions concerning the likelihood of recidivism. The regression model was significant for both regressions, indicating that the factors included in each model, as a group, explained a significant proportion of variance in participants' ratings for both the juvenile convicted of assault, $F(1, 140) = 22.35$, $p < .001$, R = .62, $R^2 = .39$, $R^2_{adj} = .37$, and the juvenile convicted of possession of an illicit drug, $F(1, 141) = 9.69$, $p < .001$, R = .46, $R^2 = .22$,

R^2_{adj} = .19. As seen in Table 4, inspection of the standardized coefficients for each predictor in the model revealed that, for both crimes, the more the participants blamed society for the juveniles' behaviors, the more they believed the 12-month sentence the juveniles received was too severe. In contrast, the more participants blamed the juveniles, themselves, for their behavior and the more they believed the juveniles would likely continue to commit crimes in the future, the more they believed the 12-month sentence the juveniles received was too lenient (i.e., not severe enough). It is important to note that while results revealed that the more participants blamed the juvenile's parents for his behavior, the more they believed the judge's sentencing decision was too lenient – this finding only emerged when participants were evaluating a juvenile who was convicted of assault. This fault attribution, reflecting the extent to which participants attributed responsibility to the juvenile's parents for his unlawful behavior, failed to uniquely predict participants' beliefs concerning the appropriateness of the sentencing decision when evaluating a juvenile convicted of a drug possession.

Discussion

The present study examined the extent to which people blame a juvenile, his parents, and society when a juvenile is convicted of a crime. In addition, we examined the role these three fault attributions uniquely impact people's perceptions concerning the appropriateness of the juvenile's punishment.

Fault Attributions

Overall, results from the present study confirm prior speculation (Brank et al., 2011) that people ultimately blame a juvenile, himself, more for ending up in the juvenile justice system than his parents or society, generally. However, and consistent with conclusions based on public opinion polls (Brank & Weisz, 2004), beyond blaming the juvenile offenders, themselves, participants attribute a great deal of blame to a juvenile's parents when a juvenile is convicted of a crime. More specifically, results from the current study revealed that participants blamed the juvenile's parents more than society generally, regardless of the type of crime (i.e., whether it was a violent crime or not). This finding is consistent with current and historical efforts to punish parents of juvenile offenders for their perceived lack of oversight over their children. Perhaps the clearest example includes parental responsibility laws within the United States and the United Kingdom in which parents can be held financially liable for the misconduct of their child. For instance, Illinois has a law (i.e., the Parental Responsibility Law, 2012) in which parents are held financially responsible for their child's "willful or malicious" behavior that results in property damage or personal injury. Such laws clearly reflect the general public's beliefs that parents are in some way responsible for their children's behavior.

It is important to note that results of the current study suggest that the extent to which people make internal vs external attributions of blame for juvenile crime depends on the type of crime. Overall, participants tended to make much more internal attributions when evaluating a juvenile convicted of a violent crime than one convicted of a nonviolent crime. That is, participants in this study blamed a juvenile convicted of assault much more for his current circumstance, and tended to blame outside forces (e.g., the juvenile's parents and society, generally) less, than one convicted of drug possession. This general pattern of findings is consistent with prior research demonstrating that people tend to make internal attributions for youth's undesirable behavior, especially when that behavior is aggressive or harmful to others (see Wadian et al., 2018). People have strong negative and punitive attitudes towards violent offenders (Ghetti & Redlich, 2001), and view those who commit violent crimes as intentionally causing harm to others.

Surprisingly, and counter to expectations based on existing literature, age of the juvenile offender failed to meaningfully affect participants' fault attributions. Although prior research (e.g., Bradley et al., 2012; Scott et al., 2005; Ghetti & Redlich, 2001) suggests that people tend to believe that younger juveniles convicted of a crime are generally less culpable than older juveniles convicted of the same crime, participants in this study did not blame the older juvenile convicted of a crime more than the younger juvenile – nor did they attribute more blame to external factors. Similar results were found in Warling and Peterson-Badali, (2003). In their study, Warling and Peterson-Badali, (2003) found that participants sentenced younger offenders to shorter sentences than older offenders; age of the offender did not significantly impact guilty verdicts. These and other findings in the literature (e.g., Ghetti & Redlich, 2001) support the growing idea that while the public has some understanding of the cognitive growth during adolescent years, they ultimately place a significant meaning on holding juvenile offenders accountable for their actions regardless of their age.

Perceptions of Punishment

The primary goal of the present investigation was to examine the extent to which people's beliefs concerning who or what is at fault for a juvenile ending up in the juvenile justice system are uniquely predictive of their beliefs concerning the appropriateness of punishing juveniles convicted of a crime. Analyses

examining participants' perceptions concerning the appropriateness of a judge's sentencing decisions of two juveniles, and factors predicting those judgments, revealed several interesting patterns of effects, which will now be discussed in turn.

The first interesting pattern of effects concerns how participants' perceptions were impacted by the circumstances provided. That is, preliminary analyses examining participants' perceptions concerning the appropriateness of a judge's sentencing of the two juveniles suggested that participants believed that a juvenile convicted of a violent crime (i.e., assault) should be punished more severely than one convicted of a nonviolent crime (i.e., drug possession), especially if the juvenile is older (i.e., 17 years old). This finding is consistent with those summarized previously (e.g., Bradely et al., 2012; Ghetti & Redlich, 2001) in which people's perceptions of a juvenile's criminal behavior, and beliefs concerning the appropriate punishment of juvenile offenders, depends largely on the situation or context. Results from the current study clearly support the overarching findings from the existing research literature that the type of crime – specifically the extent to which the crime causes personal harm – and age of the juvenile offender are two major contributing factors impacting the general public's beliefs concerning the appropriateness of sentencing decisions.

It is important to note that although the results of the present study suggest that age of the juvenile offender may play a moderating role in explaining their orientation toward punishing a juvenile offender who was convicted of a violent crime more severely than one convicted of a nonviolent crime, there was no evidence to suggest that age of the juvenile offender produced a direct effect on participants' judgments. That is, participants in the current study did not unilaterally decide that, regardless of the crime, a younger juvenile should be sentenced more leniently than an older juvenile offender. This finding is interesting because it conflicts with other findings from the existing literature demonstrating that younger juveniles are perceived as being less competent, less culpable for their actions, and less deserving of punishment (e.g., Bradley et al., 2012; Scott et al., 2005; Ghetti & Redlich, 2001). It is possible that the manipulation of age in the current study was relatively weak. That is, a 14-year-old may not have been young enough. Prior research (e.g., Ghetti & Redlich, 2001) suggests that the younger the juvenile, the less people will hold the juvenile personally responsible for the crime and the more lenient they would be in terms of punishment. Future research should continue to examine people's beliefs concerning culpability of juvenile offenders, particularly when the juvenile offender is 12 years old or younger.

The second pattern of findings that are worth noting concerns the role that participants' fault attributions play in explaining their support of the punishment the juvenile offender received. Results of the present study clearly demonstrate that while internal attributions of fault uniquely affect people's orientation toward harshly punishing juveniles convicted of a crime, individual differences in the extent to which participants blame external forces (e.g., society, generally) also impact these judgments. More specifically, while an orientation toward harshly punishing the juvenile was predicted by the extent to which participants made internal attributions for the juvenile's behavior (i.e., blamed the juvenile, himself, for ultimately ending up in the juvenile justice system), an orientation toward more leniency was predicted by the degree to which participants made external attributions for his circumstance (i.e., blaming society, generally – and to some extent, the juvenile's parents –for the juvenile ultimately ending up in the juvenile justice system). Importantly, these results further highlight the complex and sometimes conflictual cognitions people hold when it comes to juvenile justice. While people believe that juveniles *should* be punished or otherwise held accountable for their criminal behavior, they are aware that the juvenile is not the only entity or factor contributing to his behavior. People's beliefs concerning the appropriate punishment for a juvenile offender considers both internal and external factors that may have caused the juvenile's behavior.

Conclusion

The results of the present study yielded many interesting findings concerning the extent to which people blame a juvenile, his parents, and society for a juvenile's criminal behavior and how these attributions of fault uniquely impact their beliefs concerning the appropriate punishment for the juvenile's actions. In general, and consistent with prior research (e.g., Brank & Weisz, 2004), people believed that various external factors, beyond the juveniles, themselves, contribute to juvenile delinquency. Most importantly, although results of the current study clearly demonstrate that people believe both internal and external factors ultimately contribute to a juvenile's involvement in the juvenile justice system, the relative degree to which people make internal *and* external attributions for a juvenile's criminal behavior both, in their own right, appear to be important predictive factors contributing to people's beliefs concerning the appropriate punishment for juveniles convicted of a crime. Implications of the current study suggest that, beyond considering the myriad of contextual

factors that can impact public perceptions concerning the appropriate punishment of juvenile offenders convicted of a crime, future research should also consider the myriad of, and often conflicting, cognitions people may hold considering who or what is ultimately to blame.

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Appendix

Violent Crime Scenario
Crime Report: Imagine there was a 14-year-old (17-year-old) male who reportedly stabbed a man and was charged with assault. According to police reports, the juvenile stabbed the man at least two times, causing serious injuries. The judge presiding over the case sentenced the juvenile to spend 12 months at the county Juvenile Justice Center.

Drug Scenario
Crime Report: Imagine there was a 14-year-old (17-year-old) male who was reportedly stopped after Fredericksburg officers were dispatched to Pleasant Valley Apartments for suspicious persons/activity. Police conducted a search of the male which revealed possession of crystal methamphetamine. The judge presiding over the case sentenced the juvenile to 12 months at the county Juvenile Justice Center.